



Sociological perspectives

6th Topic

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MAJOR THEORETICAL PERSPECTIVES

- ❑ Before explaining theoretical perspective, it is necessary to introduce what perspective is? What is perspective?
- ❑ A perspective is a broad assumption about society and social behavior that provides a point of view for the study of specific problems.
- ❑ There are four of these general perspectives in modern sociology, evolutionary, functionalist, the conflict, and the interactionist perspectives Most of the sociologists are guided in their work by a major **theoretical perspective**.

- ⌘ Ken Brown has given the example to understand the perspective.
- ⌘ For **example**, imagine that there are five people looking at the same busy shopping street - a pickpocket, a police officer, a road sweeper, a shopper and the shopkeeper. The pickpocket sees wallets sticking out of pocket or bags, and an opportunity to steal. The police officer sees potential crime and disorder. The road sweeper litter and garbage left by everyone else. The shopper might see windows full of desirable consumer goods to buy, and the shopkeeper sees only potential customers. All are viewing the same street, but are looking at different aspects of that street what they see will depend on their perspective ' - what they are looking for. They might all be seeing different things , but you cannot really say any of their views is more correct than other - though you might think some views provide a more truthful, rounded and full description of the street than others do.

Three Perspectives Visualized

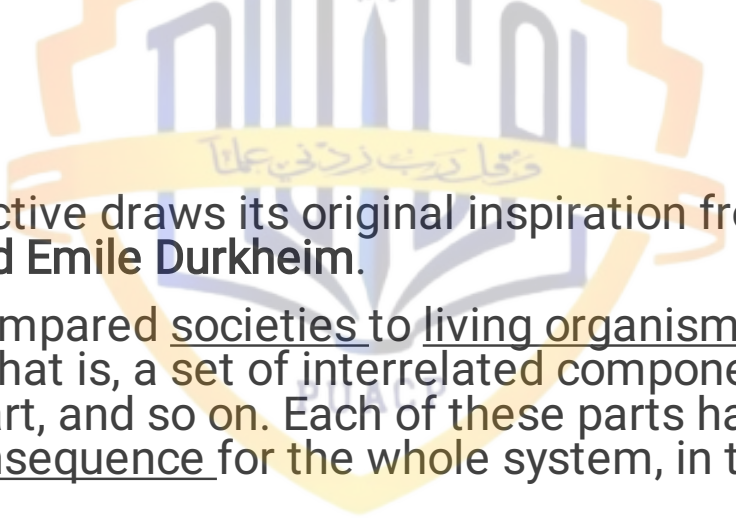
Perspective	Major Tenets PUACP	Believes that sociology should enact social change:	Macro or Micro Focus:
Structural Functionalism	Society is an organic whole of stable parts	No	Macro
Conflict	Society is a set of groups competing for power and resources	Yes	Macro
Symbolic Interactionism	Society is the sum of daily interactions guided by symbols	No	Micro

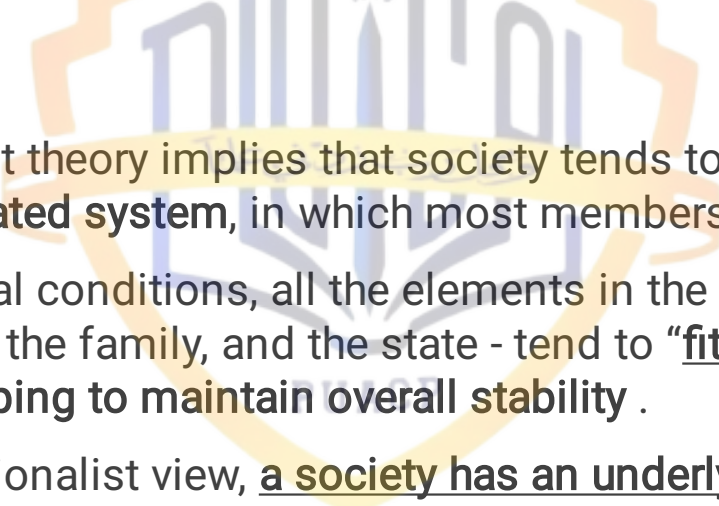
The Evolutionary Perspective

- ✘ This is the earliest perspective in sociology based on the work of **August Comte, Spencer** “It focuses on how human societies originate and grow over a period of time.” After a few decades it fell from favor, and is now once again becoming fashionable. Sociologists using this perspective look for pattern of change and development appearing in different societies in different times.

The Functionalist or Order Perspective

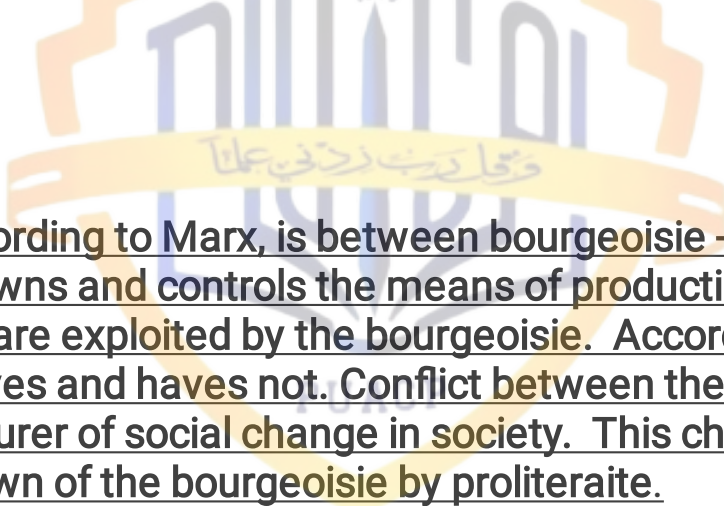
- ⌘ According to Maccionis: " **Functionalist perspective is a framework for building theory that sees society as a complex system whose parts work together to promote solidarity and stability**".
- ⌘ The functionalist perspective in sociology is a view of society that focuses on the way various parts of society have functions, or positive effects, that maintain the stability of the whole.

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- ✘ The perspective draws its original inspiration from the work of **Herbert Spencer and Emile Durkheim**.
 - ✘ Spencer compared societies to living organisms. Any organism has a **structure** - that is, a set of interrelated components, such as a head, limbs, a heart, and so on. Each of these parts has a **function** that is, a positive consequence for the whole system, in this case a living organism.
 - ✘ In the same way, Spencer argued, a **society has a structure**. Its interrelated **parts** are the **social institutions** i.e. family, religion, the military, and so on. Ideally, each of these components also has a function that contributes to the overall stability of the social system.
 - ✘ Modern structural functionalism (usually called functionalism) does not press the analogy between a society and an organism. But it does retain the same general idea of society as a system of interrelated parts.

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- ⌘ Functionalism theory implies that society tends to be an **organized, stable, well - integrated system**, in which most members **agree on basic values**.
 - ⌘ Under normal conditions, all the elements in the social system - such as the schools, the family, and the state - **tend to “fit together” with each element helping to maintain overall stability** .
 - ⌘ In the functionalist view, a society has an underlying tendency to be in equilibrium, or balance. Social change is therefore likely to be disruptive unless it takes place relatively slowly because changes in one part of the system usually provoke changes elsewhere in the system. Sudden and rapid changes caused social disruption in society.
 - ⌘ Main focus of the functionalist is on social order, stability and equilibrium in society. They believe that whenever something becomes absolutely dysfunction, automatically removed by the society. If something exists in society, no matter how negative it is, it will definitely be functional for society.

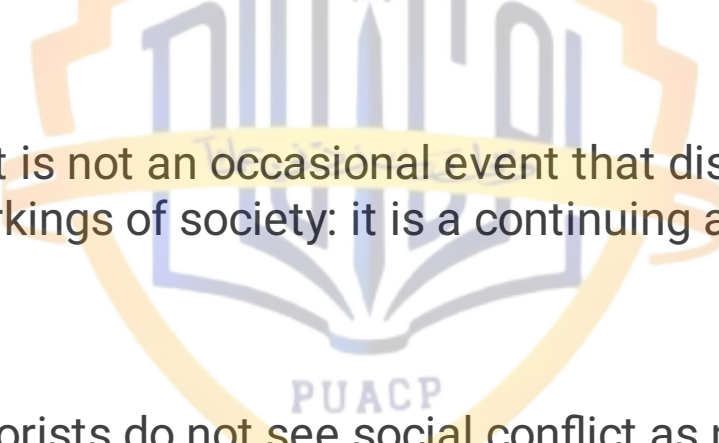
The conflict perspective

- ⌘ According to Maccionis: “ Conflict perspective is a framework for building theory that sees society as an area of inequality that generate conflict and change”.
- ⌘ The conflict perspective in sociology is a view of society that focuses on social processes of tension, competition, and change. The perspective derives its inspiration from the work of Karl Marx, who saw the struggle between social classes as the "engine" of history and the main source of change.
- ⌘ Conflict theorists assume that societies are in a constant state of change, in which conflict is a permanent feature " Conflict does not necessarily mean outright violence, it includes tension hostility, competition, and disagreement over goals and values.



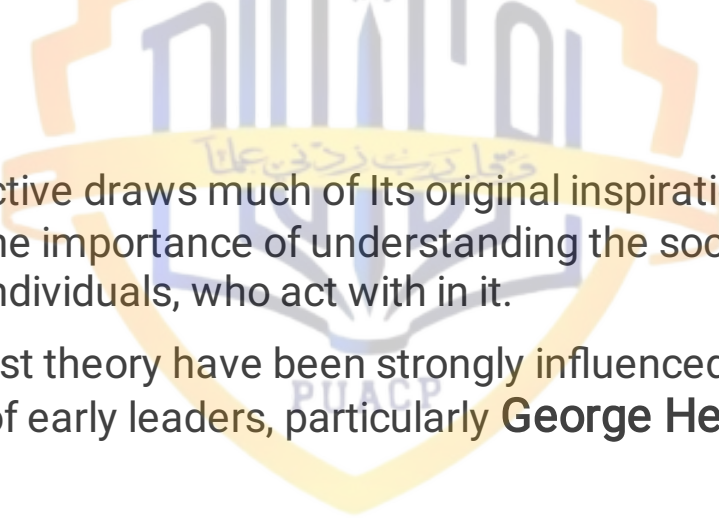
⌘ Conflict, according to Marx, is between bourgeoisie -a wealthy and powerful group who owns and controls the means of production, and proletariat-poor laborer who are exploited by the bourgeoisie. According to Marx, this conflict is between haves and have not. Conflict between these two classes according to Marx, is a source of social change in society. This change will take place after the overthrow of the bourgeoisie by proletariat.

- ⌘ Karl Marx viewed struggle between social classes as inevitable because workers are exploited under capitalism.
- ⌘ They claimed that the Capitalists exploit the working class by giving the low wages.
- ⌘ The conflict perspective encouraged the working class for gaining their rights by radical movements

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- The logo of the Philippine University of Advanced College of Psychology (PUACP) is located in the upper left background. It features a shield-like emblem with a book and a torch, with the acronym 'PUACP' below it.
- ❑ This conflict is not an occasional event that disrupts the generally smooth workings of society: it is a continuing and inevitable part of social life.
 - ❑ Conflict theorists do not see social conflict as necessarily destructive, although they admit that it may sometimes have that effect. They argue that conflict can often have positive results. It binds groups together as they pursue their own interests, and the conflict among competing groups focuses attention on social problems and leads to beneficial changes that might otherwise not have occurred.
 - ❑ In this way, social movements-such as those for women's rights or against nuclear power-become an important source of change. The changes caused by social conflict prevent society from stagnating.

The interactionist perspective

- ⌘ According to Maccionis : “it’s broad focus on social structures that shape society as a whole”.
- ⌘ **Symbolic interaction** is the interaction that takes place between people through symbols. Much of this interaction takes place on a face-to-face basis but it can also occur in other forms: symbolic interaction is taking place between you and the author as you read this sentence, and it occurs whenever you obey (or disobey) a traffic signal or a no-trespassing notice. The essential point is that people do not respond to the world directly they place a social meaning on it and respond to that meaning. The words of this ppt, the red light of a traffic signal a wolf whistle in the street, have no meaning in themselves, rather, people learn to attach symbolic meaning to these things, and they order their lives on the basis of these meanings. We live in a symbolic as well as in a physical world, and our social life involves a constant process of interpreting the meanings of our own acts and those of others.

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- ✘ The perspective draws much of its original inspiration from **Max Weber**, who emphasize the importance of understanding the social world from the view point of the individuals, who act with in it.
 - ✘ Interactionalist theory have been strongly influenced by social psychology and by the work of early leaders, particularly **George Herbert Mead**.
 - ✘ The main reason interactionist theorists are wary of the emphasis of other sociologists place on the major components of society is that concepts such as “the economy” or “the state” are. After all, abstractions: they cannot exist or act by themselves. It is people that exist and act, and is only "through their social behavior that society can come into being at all. Society is ultimately created, maintained, and changed by the social interaction of its members.

Criticism / Difference between symbolic and other two perspectives

- ✘ The interactionist perspective provides a fascinating insight into the mechanics of everyday life, and it has the advantage of revealing fundamental social processes that other perspectives easily overlook. But the perspective is open to the important criticism that it neglects larger social institutions and societal processes of stability and change-institutions and processes which, after all, have powerful effects on social interaction and on our personal experience.

Difference between symbolic and other two perspectives/ Criticism

- ✘ The important difference between this perspective and the two we have considered is that it does not focus on such large structures as the state, the economy, or social classes. Instead, it concerned primarily with the everyday social interaction that takes place as people go about their lives.



Extra

- ✘ The interactionist perspective focuses on social behavior in everyday life. It tries to understand how people create and interpret the situations they experience, and it emphasizes how countless instances of social interaction produce the larger structure of society government, the economy and other institutions.
- ✘ This perspective presumes that it is only through these social behavior of the people that society can come into being. Society is ultimately created, maintained and changed by the social interaction of its members